

Session 38: Does God Change His Mind?

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew word *nikham* invites us into the deep mystery of God's purpose to partner with humans in the course of history.
- No matter what the people do, God never goes back on his covenant purpose to use this family to bless the nations.

The Repentance of Nineveh: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 3:5-10

The Ninevites Respond

A 5 And the men of Nineveh believed in God,
and **they called a fast** ,
and they were **clothed with sackcloth** ,
from the **great** of them and to the small of them.

The King Responds

B a 6 And the word reached to the king of Nineveh
b **and he arose from his throne**
c and he removed his robe from upon him
c' and he **covered with sackcloth**
b' **and he sat in the dust** .
a' 7 And he cried out, and he said:

The King's Edict

"In Nineveh, from order of the king and his great ones, saying:

a **The human and the beast** ,
the cattle and the flock,
don't let them **taste anything** ;

don't let them graze;

A' ^b and **don't let them** **drink** water,
⁸ and **let them** **cover themselves with sackcloth**,

^{a'} **the human and the beast**,
 and **let them** call to god with force,

^{b'} and **let each** **man** **turn** **from his** **evil** **way**
 and from the violence that is in his hands.

⁹ Who knows?
 The god **may** turn **and** **repent**
and **turn** **from the** **heat of his anger**,
 so that we will not perish.

God's Response to the Ninevites' Repentance

C ¹⁰ And God saw their doings,
 that **they** **turned** **from their** **evil** **way**,
 and **God** **repented** **concerning the** **evil**
 which he spoke to do to them,
 and he did not do it.

Jonah 3:5-10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

The Symmetry of the Ninevite Response

The actions of the Ninevites (A) anticipate the edict of the king (A'). They fast before they're told to, and their belief is a forward fulfillment of the king's call to "turn and repent." This characterizes the people as so eager to repent that the king's edict only states explicitly what they are already inclined to do without being commanded.

In B, notice how the king's actions are a symmetrical mirror. A word comes to the king (a) and then goes out from him (a'). He rises from his throne (b) and then sits down in ashes (b'). And at the center, he takes off his royal robe (c) only to put on sackcloth (c'). It's a complete reversal of his words, his role in society, and his symbols of high status.

In A', there is a forward symmetry so that in a and a', the king's edict addresses human and beast, while in b and b', we have an increasing series of deprivations ("don't let them ..."), leading up to the ultimate prohibition: "let each turn from his evil way ..."

In C, there is a climactic ending as God responds to the Ninevites' response. His actions match the actions of the Ninevites. They repent, so he relents.

Faithful Ninevites

The depiction of the Ninevites' faith in God activates an analogy with the Israelites immediately after their rescue from the sea. Recall that the first half of this analogy was applied to the sailors in Jonah 1:16, and now the second half is applied to the Ninevites in Jonah 3:5.

Israelites at the Sea

Exodus 14:31 NIV*

And the Israelites saw the great hand which Yahweh acted against Egypt **and the people feared Yahweh** (ויראו את יהוה) and **they believed in Yahweh** (ב ויאמינו) and in Moses his servant.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Sailors and the Ninevites

Jonah 1:16 Instructor's Translation

And the sailors **feared Yahweh** (ויראו יהוה את) a great fear ...

Jonah 3:5 ESV*

And the men of Nineveh **believed in God** (ויאמינו באלהים).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This analogy creates an ironic contrast, as Jonah is the one being rescued from the sea. But unlike the Exodus story, it is the pagan sailors and Ninevites who fear and believe in God.

Repenting Ninevites and a Relenting God

The king's edict to the Ninevites activates analogies with both Moses and Jeremiah.

Moses

Exodus 32:12, 14 Instructor's Translation

¹² [Moses to Yahweh] Turn from the heat of your anger (שוב מחרון אפך) and relent concerning the evil toward your people (הנחם ... על הרעה). ... ¹⁴ And Yahweh relented concerning the evil which he spoke to his people. (לעשות לעמו יהוה על הרעה אשר דבר וינחם).

The Ninevites

Jonah 3:8-10 NASB*

⁸ Let each man turn from his evil way (הרעה וישבו איש מדרכו) ... ⁹ Who knows, God may relent and turn from the heat of his anger (פיושב ונחם ... מחרון) and we will not perish! ¹⁰ And God saw ... that they turned from their evil way (מדרכם הרעהשבו), and God relented concerning the evil which he spoke to do to them (דבר לעשות להם הרעה אשר וינחם האלהים על).

Jeremiah

Jeremiah 18:7-8 Instructor's Translation

⁷ I may speak concerning a nation ... to destroy it, ⁸ but if that nation turns from its evil (מרע תושב), then I will relent concerning the evil I planned to do to it (חשבתי לעשות לוונחמתי על הרעה אשר).

Jeremiah 26:3 NASB*

Perhaps they will listen and each will turn from his evil way (וישב איש מדרכו הרעה), and I will relent concerning the evil which I am planning to do to them (חשב לעשות להם אל הרעה אשר אנכי נחמתי).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In both the stories of Moses and Jeremiah, the prophet plays the role of mediator. Moses appeals to God to “turn” from his just anger and not do “evil” to the people. Jeremiah appeals to the people to “turn” from their “evil” so God will relent from the “evil” he plans to do.

The irony is that Jonah, unlike Moses and Jeremiah, has abdicated his role as prophetic mediator, yet unlike the Jerusalemites, the Ninevites do repent!

God's Repentance

In Jonah 3:10, God sees the repentance of the Ninevites, so he relents of the disaster he had spoken to do to them. This vocabulary of human and divine repentance permeates the Hebrew Scriptures and gives us important insight into the purposes and ways of God in his dealings with humans.

The Vocabulary

When humans repent from evil, they *shuv* (pronounced "shooove"). It literally means to “turn around.”

When God repents from bringing evil on evil people, he can *shuv*, but there is an additional word used, *nikham*, which means “to relent, be satisfied.”

The root *nikham* is capable of different nuances based on context. In the active/causative form (*piel*), it can mean to comfort or change someone's emotional or mental state.

Genesis 24:67 NIV

And [Isaac] married Rebekah ... and [he] was **comforted** after his mother's death.

Genesis 37:35 NIV

[Jacob's] sons and daughters came **to comfort him**, but he refused to be **comforted**.

In the reflexive form (*niphal*), it can mean to regret a past action or to change one's mind about a future action.

Genesis 6:6 NIV*

And Yahweh **regretted** that he had made humanity on the land, and his heart was deeply pained.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Samuel 24:16 NIV*

And the angel stretched out his hand to destroy Jerusalem, and Yahweh **relented** concerning the evil and said ... “Stop your hand.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In each example of Yahweh’s relenting, the focus is on his purpose to bring judgment or blessing on violent people.

Jeremiah 18:7-10 NASB*

⁷ At one moment I might speak concerning a nation or concerning a kingdom to uproot, to pull down, or to destroy it; ⁸ if that nation against which I have spoken turns from its evil, **I will relent** concerning the evil I planned to bring on it. ⁹ Or at another moment I might speak concerning a nation or concerning a kingdom to build up or to plant it; ¹⁰ if it does evil in my sight by not obeying my voice, then **I will relent** concerning the good with which I had promised to bless it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The God of the Bible has partnered with humans ([Gen. 1:26-28](#)), and he experiences emotional pain over their evil (Gen. 6:6). God is portrayed as carrying out his ultimate purposes for history and all creation regardless of what humans do. This is the core idea in stories that portray God as not changing his mind even while clearly responding to human decisions.

1 Samuel 15:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ Then the word of the LORD came to Samuel: ¹¹ “I **nikham** that I have made Saul king, because he has turned away from following me and has not carried out my commands.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Samuel 15:28-29 NIV*

²⁸ Samuel said to him, “The LORD has torn the kingdom of Israel from you today and has given it to one of your neighbors—to one better than you. ²⁹ He who is the Glory of Israel does not lie or **nikham**; for he is not a human being, that he should **nikham**.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The statement in 15:29 is matched by [Numbers 23:19](#).

1 Samuel 15:35 NIV*

Until the day Samuel died, he did not go to see Saul again, though Samuel mourned for him. And the LORD **nikham** that he had made Saul king over Israel.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The relenting of God due to the Ninevites' repentance is a hyperlinked inversion of the golden calf story in Exodus 32. There, Moses stepped into his role as mediator (unlike Jonah), and his intercession is what compels God to relent.

Exodus 32:9-11 NASB*

⁹ Then Yahweh said to Moses ... ¹⁰ "Now then let me alone (הניחה lit. "give me rest"), that my anger may burn against them and that I may destroy them; and I will make of you a great nation." ¹¹ But Moses entreated the LORD his God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"This story explores the mystery about prayer in general and intercession in particular, and raises questions: Was God really serious in this declared threat? If Moses had not interceded, would God have carried out the destruction of Israel? If God was not really planning to destroy the people, did God only 'pretend' to listen to Moses' prayer? Did Moses actually change God's mind?

It seems important first of all to say that there is not much point in wrestling with these alternative hypothetical scenarios posed by such questions. Both God and Moses appear to be behaving straightforwardly. There is nothing in the text to suggest that God's anger was overdone for mere effect. The threat of destruction was real, and Moses recognized that this was a sincere threat that could be countered only with appeal to prior words and actions of the same God.

The real paradox is that in appealing to God to change, Moses was actually appealing to God to be consistent, which may be a significant clue to the dynamic of all genuine intercessory prayer. Yet perhaps there is a hint of the divine intention in God's fascinating words, 'Leave me alone ...' The discussion of this line in Jewish scholarship has sensed deep meaning here. After all, God need not have spoken such words, or indeed any words at all, to Moses. In wrath God could have acted 'immediately' without informing or consulting Moses in any way. God pauses and makes the divine will 'vulnerable' to human challenge.

The fact is that, far from human intercession being an irritating but occasionally successful intrusion upon divinely prefabricated blueprints for history, Moses' prayer becomes an integral part of the way God's sovereignty in history is exercised. That does not totally solve the mystery, but it puts it in its proper biblical perspective. God not only allows human intercession, God invites it and builds it into the decision-making processes of the heavenly council in ways we can never fathom. Intercessory prayer, then, flows primarily not from human anxiety about God but from God's commitment to covenant relationship with human beings. Moses was not so much arguing against God, as participating in an argument within God. Such prayer, therefore, not only participates in the pain of God in history, but is actually invited to do so for God's sake as well as ours. This is a measure of the infinite value to God of commitment to persons in covenant relationship."

Adapted from Wright, Christopher (1994). [*Deuteronomy*](#). Baker Books. 78-79.

Reflection Question

How do you understand the idea of God changing his mind or relenting (Hebrew: *nikham*)? How does this understanding affect how you and others in your context view God and interact with him?